



Choosing Where to Locate Your Start-Up

Finding a good location for your business can be vital. It will affect your costs and may influence the number and type of customers or clients you attract. Making the best choice relies on careful analysis.

Assessing what you need

Your line of business will determine the sort of location you need and how important a role location plays. If planning to open a restaurant or store, for example, you need to be where you can maximize trade, but location is less critical if you work largely online, manufacture goods, or sell to trade buyers. Even so, you

may need to consider costs, such as rent, storage, and transportation, and what working environment will make you feel comfortable.

Unless you work from home, you will need safe, secure premises in a neighborhood that you and any employees and clients can travel to easily. Parking spaces and easy access may also be essential.

Researching the area

First, decide on your key criteria such as “on a main shopping street” for a retail outlet or “near a station” if your business relies on client visits. Research information about an area and its available business premises, and visit commercial property agents. Try to single out areas where special deals, such as

Questions to ask yourself

Before starting your search for business premises, work through this list of questions. Be as honest as you can about the answers, as commitments can be difficult to undo once you make a decision. Also, think about your future needs. Working from home may initially save costs, but it could leave you without the space to expand your business. Once your business is up and running and you can assess, forecast, and monitor its growth and development, it may be worth setting out a plan for finding the right location for expansion when it reaches a certain size.



Do I really need physical premises?

Many businesses can simply be run from home, such as those selling online. If you need to make alterations to your home in order to sell, make sure you follow local planning rules. If you intend to prepare or sell food from your own kitchen, adhere to health and safety regulations (see pp.212–215).



What type of premises?

Most people setting up a business will rent or lease their premises. Think about the space you will require. How much storage is necessary? Do you need an area for preparing food? Can the existing premises be adapted to create more space and facilities?



Who are my customers or clients?

If customers or clients will be visiting your premises, you will need to consider facilities for them, such as parking spaces and possibly toilets. If your business provides a service to the public, you will also need to ensure that your location is fully accessible and complies with ADA rules and code.



What sort of building and area will best suit my business?

Think about the type of space you need to accommodate employees, customers, or clients. Consider the feel of the surrounding neighborhood, the look of the premises from the outside, and whether its internal layout and design match your business's needs.